

insight ■ workshop



Safety first

The high reliability of modern hardware makes backups seem pointless, but there is no shortage of reasons for data loss—viruses, hardware failures, software errors, carelessness or plain bad luck. There is no sure-fire way of preventing an accident, so taking backups religiously might just save the day. If you don't back up, you will learn its value the hard way.

Think of how easy life can become if you maintain regular backups. Should you lose your data, all you have to do is launch the backup software and hit restore! Depending on how often you take backups, the copy could be as recent as a few changes old.

There are some cardinal rules of taking backups. Back up everything you can

fit into your budget—the more you back up, the less time you will have to spend redoing. Check the integrity of your data; mirroring corrupted data is obviously useless. Test the backups regularly—the backup media could wear out over time, or the backup files may get corrupted if the backup process is interrupted.

Take backups as frequently as the data changes. Some data files need to be backed up more frequently than others, but for any changes that you can't redo, back up at least once a day. Maintain more than one backup if your budget allows it and keep them in different places—this protects the backup media from physical damage. Retain some old backups—this will come in handy if a newer copy gets corrupted. Depending on the volume and type of data, this could be anything from a couple of weeks to a few months old. Finally, make sure your backups are as secure as your original data. This applies to work environments as well as at home—if there's something you don't want others to see, they should not be able to get hold of it from your backups.

Before you start taking backups, identify what to back up. For businesses there is a simple answer—everything. In a networked environment, a virus can wreak havoc with entire departments. When every minute of computer downtime can be measured in money, a backup system is a safety net you can't ignore. Of course, this level of backup may be overkill for most individuals and small businesses. You should still try to back up anything that you can't otherwise replace. This eliminates Windows and most application programs. While reinstalling and reconfiguring these can be a long and arduous job (see *Digit*, October 2002, 'For a painless reinstall'), their loss is not irrecoverable.

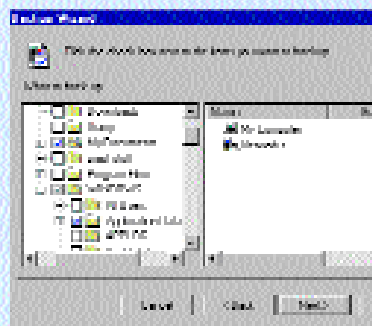
Of all the data on your hard disk (some hiding in places you wouldn't expect) what you choose to back up depends on

the amount of space you have on backup media and its importance to you. Organise all your files in one top-level folder, such as My Documents. This reduces the effort needed to hunt down the data you need to back up. You should also look at data files of other applications, such as Internet Explorer Favorites, address books, etc.

Using Microsoft Backup

You don't need to look far for backup software. Microsoft Backup is a free utility that comes with Windows 98. If you already have it installed, open **Control Panel > Add/Remove Programs > Windows Setup > Accessories > System Tools > Backup**. Select System Tools and click **Details**. Check the box next to Backup and click **OK**. Your way through the dialog box to launch Microsoft Backup is a scaled-down version of Seagate's Backup Exec. It supports backing up to SCSI and IDE devices such as tape drives and CDs and to networked shared folders on another computer. It can compress backups, reducing space requirements and verify the integrity after it's done. It supports incremental and differential backup.

On launching the software (**Start > Programs > Accessories > System Tools > Backup**) it presents you with three choices. 'Create a New Backup Job' and follow the wizard. If you want to choose which



Choose the files and folders you want to backup



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